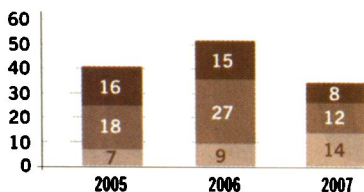
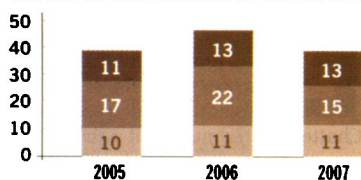


TIME SPENT IN DEBATING A BILL: LOK SABHA



■ Less than 20 min ■ 20 min to 2 hrs ■ 2 hrs +
Finance and Appropriation Bills are not included

TIME SPENT IN DEBATING A BILL: RAJYA SABHA



■ Less than 20 min ■ 20 min to 2 hrs ■ 2 hrs +
Finance and Appropriation Bills are not included

Courtesy: PRS Legislative Research

trust vote. It was convened on October 17 and was to go on until November 21. But the Government sprang a surprise by adjourning the House abruptly until December 10, the alibi being the festive season and the elections in five states that kept most MPs to their constituencies. The Government knew that both Diwali and the Assembly elections were on the way when it convened the House. It hopes that the continuation of the same session would save it from the task of proving majority in the House again. The BJP questions the Government's plans to evade a no-trust vote. Opposition leader L.K. Advani said, "The trust-vote motion was not initiated by the Opposition. Suppose the support to the Government again changes within six months, can it then be argued that the Government has no cause to prove its majority on the floor of the Lok Sabha?"

The Government, on the other hand, is in denial mode. "There is no problem. We found it convenient. We have a majority. The suggestion to adjourn came from the principal opposition party, the BJP," says Parliamentary Affairs Minister Vayalar Ravi. The BJP may not be in a mood to initiate a no-confidence motion as the Government completes the last stretch but its decision to swallow the winter session explains the UPA's lack of commitment to

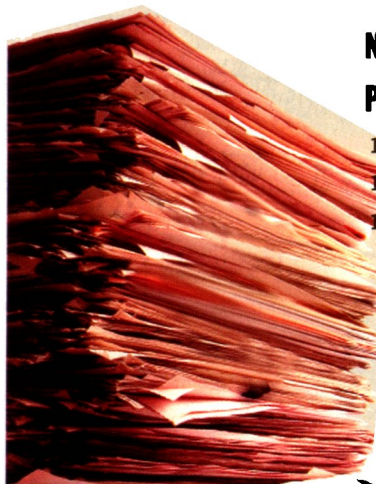
Stalled in Sloth

In September 2005, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh met some investors and bankers in New York. They asked him why India should have a banking law that denies the shareholders basic democratic rights. The current laws allow owners voting rights of only 10 per cent whatever their shareholding be. The prime minister promised investors and bankers that on his return, the law would be amended. Now after 37 months, the UPA has been unable to deliver on its promise. You could say that the Government couldn't act thanks to an intransigent Left. But then you could wonder if the nuke deal could go through, why this simple amendment did not.

The fate of the Banking Regulation Amendment Bill of 2005 is testimony to the inability of this Government to argue the case for reforms as well as the legislative logjam in the 14th Lok Sabha. It isn't just banking reforms. Critical legislation that could boost or mar the potential of a sector or an initiative is trapped in the long winding corridors of committees, commissions and group of ministers.

The fact that many of the bills have been travelling this maze since 2005 gives you an idea of the urgency and the initiative that has been exhibited to push their own ideas. The Special Economic Zones, for instance, were devised as a vehicle to create job opportunities for those stuck in the rural economy thereby creating sustainable incomes. On June 23, 2005, the Special Economic Zone (SEZ) Bill was passed by Parliament into a law. Six months later, in February 2006, the Ministry of Commerce notified the rules. The bill itself was passed in July 2005 without much ado. It was only when the norms were notified in February 2006 that the political class—even within the UPA who had voted for the bill—discovered they had issues. An empowered group of ministers (EGOM) was set up to discuss everything from the size of the SEZs to the quantum of tax exemptions. It is instructive that even now in October 2008, the EGOM continues to meet to discuss minutiae ranging from service tax exemptions to land acquisition and resettlement issues.

There is no doubt that the Left



NUMBER OF BILLS PASSED BY PARLIAMENT

